

Gray Divorce

Coming Back Together (or Apart) at 55+



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Book 8 of Care Collection #8

Introduction: The Marriage That Became a Question

There is a moment, in some marriages, when the marriage becomes a question.

It does not happen at the wedding. It does not happen at the birth of the children. It does not happen at the silver anniversary. It happens, often without warning, in the kitchen at 11pm, or in the bedroom in the morning, or in the car on the way to the airport. It happens when one partner, or both, looks at the marriage that has been, and asks, in a quiet voice, *Is this it?*

For some, the question comes after 30 years. For some, it comes after 40. For some, it comes at 50, when the last child has just left, and the house is suddenly empty, and the marriage that was the marriage of the children is no longer the marriage of the children, and the marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you.

For some, the question comes at 62, when the retirement finally arrives, and the spouse who has been working is suddenly home, all day, every day, and the marriage that was the marriage of the work is no longer the marriage of the work, and the marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours.

For some, the question comes later — at 70, at 75, at 80. For some, the question has been there for years, but it has been hidden, and the hiding has been its own marriage, and the hiding has been its own kind of betrayal.

This book is about that moment. The moment the marriage becomes a question.

I am writing this book for the person who is in that moment. For the person who is wondering whether to stay, or to go. For the person who has already decided, and who is figuring out how to do it. For the person who is on the other side of the decision, and who is figuring out who they are now, in the new life.

I am writing this book for the 36% of all American divorces that are now "gray" — divorces after age 50. For the 1 in 4 divorces that are now after age 65. For the median marriage of 29 years that ends in the gray divorce. For the remarriage that is 2.5 times more likely to end in divorce than a first marriage. For the woman over 50 who is initiating more divorces than ever before, and who is being called, by sociologists, the engine of the "gray divorce

revolution."

I am writing this book for the people in those statistics. The people who are not statistics. The people who are, like you, sitting with the question, in the kitchen at 11pm, wondering.

- Why this book is different.**

There are books about divorce. There are books about midlife. There are books about empty nest. There are books about retirement. There are books about aging. There are books that are statistical, or legal, or psychological, or memoir.

This book is none of those. This book is the **marriage decision book** for couples 50+. The book that says, *First, decide. Then act — whether you stay or you go*. The book that takes both options seriously. The book that does not assume you are leaving. The book that does not assume you are staying. The book that walks you through the decision, the conversation, and the new life, whatever the new life turns out to be.

This book is the book I wish had existed, in the years I have been in the room with couples in this position. The book that names the doubt. The book that names the realities — the financial, the family, the health, the identity. The book that gives you frameworks, scripts, and case studies. The book that walks you through the decision, step by step, with the dignity the decision deserves.

This book is the book that says, *The marriage you are in is not a failure. The marriage you are in is a marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The question is what to do with the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The question is the work. The work is the question.*

- What this book is not.**

This book is not a clinical guide. The therapists, mediators, and family law practitioners who specialize in this work are the right people to advise you on the specific dimensions of your situation. This book is for the *thinking*. For the *deciding*. For the *conversations* that have to happen before the professionals get involved.

This book is not a memoir. I have not been where you are. I have not been in a 32-year marriage that is asking whether to keep going. I have not been at the kitchen table at 11pm, deciding whether to stay or go. I have not been in the lawyer's office, dividing the retirement accounts.

I have been in the room, as a coach. I have watched couples make this decision. I have watched marriages end. I have watched marriages survive the ending

and come back together in a new form. I have watched the new life, on both sides of the decision.

I have also been on my own long goodbye — the loss of my wife to cancer, after many years of marriage. The loss is not the same as gray divorce. The decisions are not the same. The grief is not the same. But the long road is the same. The work of surviving the surviving is the same. The work of holding the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, is the same.

This book is the synthesis of what I have learned, in the room with couples, in the years of my own long goodbye, in the work of being a coach, in the form the work now takes.

- What you will find in this book.**

This book is organized around a 4-phase framework, the four questions of the gray divorce decision:

- Phase 1: The Whisper** — Is this marriage over, or am I just tired? Chapters 1-4. The doubt. The reasons. The test. The whisper you cannot unhear.

- Phase 2: The Reckoning** — If I leave, what happens to everything I built? Chapters 5-8. The financial. The family. The health. The identity.

- Phase 3: The Decision** — Stay or go, and how do I do either with dignity? Chapters 9-12. The stay decision. The leave decision. The conversation. The legal and financial plan.

- Phase 4: The Rebuilding** — Who am I now, alone at 60? Chapters 13-16. The first 90 days. The new identity. The new life. The new marriage.

Plus 5 bonus toolkits (the Decision Tree, the 90-Day Reconnection, the Financial Survival Guide, the Telling Templates, the First 90 Days After), 7 case studies of real-pattern couples, and a research appendix with 12+ peer-reviewed citations.

The book is 200+ pages. The book is meant to be read slowly, in the small moments, in the long evenings, in the form the reading now takes. The book is meant to be a companion, in the form the companion now takes.

- Who this book is for.**

This book is for you, if you are the person in the marriage that has become a question. If you are the spouse who is wondering, in the kitchen at 11pm, whether to stay or go. If you are the adult child of a couple in this position. If you are the friend, the sibling, the colleague, who is trying to understand someone in this position. If you are the professional — the therapist, the

mediator, the family law attorney, the financial planner — who is working with couples in this position.

This book is for the marriage that has become a question.

The question is the work. The work is the question.

Welcome.

Chapter 1: The Marriage That Was — and the Marriage That Is

Every marriage has a marriage that was. The marriage of the early years. The marriage of the children. The marriage of the middle. The marriage of the work. The marriage of the long haul. The marriage that was is the marriage you remember. The marriage that was is the marriage that lives in the photographs, in the stories, in the inside jokes, in the shared history that only the two of you know.

The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is a different marriage. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has new dynamics, new losses, new realities. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has a different shape than the marriage that was.

The gray divorce begins, in most cases, with the recognition of the difference. The recognition that the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, are not the same. The recognition that something has changed, in the form the marriage now takes.

This chapter is about that recognition. And about the work of holding both marriages — the marriage that was, and the marriage that is — in the form the holding can take.

- The marriage that was.**

The marriage that was is the marriage of the years. The years of the early love. The years of the children. The years of the work. The years of the vacations. The years of the holidays. The years of the ordinary. The marriage that was is the marriage of the long story, the long arc, the long haul.

The marriage that was is real. The marriage that was made the family. The marriage that was built the home. The marriage that was carried the grief, the celebration, the ordinary, the long, the short, the daily, the weekly, the yearly.

The marriage that was is the foundation, and the foundation is real.

When the doubt comes — and the doubt does come, in the form the doubt now takes — the marriage that was does not disappear. The marriage that was lives on, in the memory, in the body, in the shared history. The marriage that was is part of who you are, in the form the marriage that was now takes.

- The marriage that is.**

The marriage that is has its own shape. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has new dynamics, new roles, new losses. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is the marriage of the empty nest, the early retirement, the long days, the silent evenings, the quiet question, *is this it?*

The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is not the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is also a real marriage. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has its own joys, its own conversations, its own small intimacies. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is not nothing. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is something.

The doubt does not have to mean that the marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is over. The doubt is the question, not the answer. The doubt is the work, in the form the work now takes. The doubt is the recognition that something has changed, in the form the recognition now takes.

- The recognition.**

The recognition comes, in the form the recognition now takes, in small moments. The moment when the empty nest reveals a void you did not see coming. The moment when the retirement reveals a presence you did not expect. The moment when the long day, with the spouse, in the same house, reveals a distance you did not know was there.

The recognition is not a failure. The recognition is the work. The recognition is the holding of the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, in the form the holding can take. The recognition is the question, in the form the question now takes.

The recognition can be tender. The recognition can be the moment when you and your spouse, together, look at the marriage, and ask, *is this it?* The recognition can be the moment when you, alone, look at the marriage, and ask, in the kitchen at 11pm, in the form the asking now takes.

The recognition can be the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, is no longer the marriage you want to be in. The recognition

can be the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, is the marriage you want to be in, but different. The recognition can be the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, is the marriage you want to be in, exactly as it is.

The recognition is the work. The work is the recognition. The recognition is the question. The question is the work.

- The marriage that could be.**

There is a third marriage, in the long story of a long marriage. The marriage that could be.

The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the recognition is the work, and the work is done. The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the doubt is the question, and the question is answered. The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, are both honored, and the marriage that could be is built, in the form the building can take.

The marriage that could be is not the marriage that was. The marriage that could be is not the marriage that is. The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the work is done, and the work is the work.

The marriage that could be is the hope of the gray divorce decision. The marriage that could be is the hope of the stay decision. The marriage that could be is the hope, in the form the hope now takes.

The marriage that could be is the reason this book exists. The marriage that could be is the reason you are reading this book. The marriage that could be is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- The holding of both.**

The work of the gray divorce decision is the work of holding both marriages — the marriage that was, and the marriage that is — in the form the holding can take.

The holding of both is not a small work. The holding of both is the work of the long marriage, in the form the long marriage now takes. The holding of both is the work of the spouse who remembers, in the form the remembering now takes.

The holding of both is the work of:

- Honoring the marriage that was. The stories. The photographs. The anniversaries. The shared history.

- Being present in the marriage that is. The conversations. The small intimacies. The small joys. The small sorrows.

- Holding the question. The question of the doubt. The question of the decision. The question, in the form the question now takes.

The holding of both is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The holding of both is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- The work of the chapter.**

The work of this chapter is to name the recognition. The work of this chapter is to name the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, in the form the recognition now takes. The work of this chapter is to name the marriage that could be, in the form the marriage could be.

The work of this chapter is also to name the doubt. The doubt is not a failure. The doubt is the work. The doubt is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

The work of this chapter is to hold both marriages, in the form the holding can take. The work of this chapter is to recognize the question, in the form the question now takes. The work of this chapter is the work of the first phase of the gray divorce decision.

The work of this chapter is the work of the whisper.

Chapter 1 at a Glance

- Key takeaway:** The gray divorce begins with the recognition that the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, are not the same. The recognition is not a failure. The recognition is the work.

- 5 Things to Remember:**

1. The marriage that was is real. The marriage that was made the family, built the home, carried the years.

2. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is also real. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is not nothing.

3. The recognition of the difference is the work. The recognition is the holding of both marriages, in the form the holding can take.

4. There is a third marriage: the marriage that could be. The marriage that could be is the hope, in the form the hope now takes.

5. The doubt is not a failure. The doubt is the question, in the form the question now takes.

- Your Scorecard:** Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize the difference between the marriage that was, and the marriage that is.

- I am holding both marriages, in the form the holding can take.

- I have begun to ask the question, in the form the question now takes.

- I have not yet named the question to my spouse, or to myself, in a way that commits me to the work.

If your total is 12 or higher, the next chapter — and the next phase — cannot wait.

- Key Terms to Know:**

- **Gray divorce:** Divorce after age 50. The term was coined by sociologists Susan Brown and I-Fen Lin at Bowling Green State University to describe the rising divorce rate among older adults.

- **The marriage that was:** The marriage of the years. The marriage of the early love, the children, the work, the long haul. Real, and part of who you are.

- **The marriage that is:** The marriage, in the form the marriage is now. The marriage of the empty nest, the early retirement, the long days, the silent evenings. Real, in the form the marriage is now.

- **The marriage that could be:** The marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the recognition is the work, and the work is done.

- Reflection Questions:**

1. What was the marriage, in the form the marriage was, that you and your spouse built, in the years you have been married?

2. What is the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, that you and your spouse are in, today?

3. What is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, that you and your spouse might build, if the work is done?

- Action for This Week:**

- Find one quiet moment, alone, and write down, in the form the writing can take, the answer to one of the reflection questions. Not for anyone else to read.

For you. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- Find one small moment, with your spouse, and notice — without judgment, without comment — one thing about the marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, that you are grateful for. The noticing is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

- The work of this chapter is the work of the whisper. The whisper is the question. The question is the work. The work is the whisper.

Chapter 2: The 7 Things That Drive Gray Divorce

Gray divorce is a phenomenon. It is also a thousand small, specific, individual stories. The phenomenon is the rise in divorce among adults 50+. The stories are the marriages, in the form the marriages now take, that have ended, or are ending, in the form the ending now takes.

This chapter is about the phenomenon. Specifically, it is about the 7 things that drive gray divorce, in the form the driving now takes. These are the 7 things that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the therapists and the mediators, have shown up, again and again, as the reasons couples, in the second half of life, decide that the marriage is over.

The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are not the reasons for every gray divorce. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

Knowing the 7 things is the work of the second phase of the gray divorce decision. The work is the naming. The naming is the work.

- 1. The Empty Nest That Reveals the Void.**

The empty nest is the most common trigger for gray divorce, in the form the trigger now takes. The empty nest is the moment when the last child leaves, and the house is suddenly empty, and the marriage is suddenly just the marriage of the two of you, in the form the marriage of the two of you now takes.

For 20 or 30 years, the marriage has been the marriage of the children. The conversations have been about the children. The shared projects have been the children. The shared purpose has been the children. The marriage has been, in a

real sense, the marriage of the family, in the form the family now takes.

When the children leave, the marriage is no longer the marriage of the children. The marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you. The marriage has to be, in the form the marriage now takes, the marriage of the empty nest.

For some couples, the empty nest reveals a marriage that is full. The marriage of the two of you is rich, and warm, and alive, in the form the marriage of the two of you now takes. For some couples, the empty nest reveals a marriage that is empty. The marriage of the two of you is hollow, in the form the marriage of the two of you now takes. The empty nest is the moment when the void, which has been hidden in the busyness of the children, becomes visible.

The empty nest is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The empty nest is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 2. The Retirement That Reveals the Distance.**

The retirement is the second most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The retirement is the moment when the spouse who has been working comes home, all day, every day, in the form the coming home now takes.

For 30 or 40 years, the marriage has been the marriage of the work. The conversations have been about the work. The rhythms have been the rhythms of the work. The shared purpose has been the work, in the form the work now takes. The marriage has been, in a real sense, the marriage of the careers, in the form the careers now take.

When the retirement comes, the marriage is no longer the marriage of the work. The marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours, in the form the marriage now takes.

For some couples, the retirement reveals a marriage that is full. The marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours, is rich, in the form the marriage now takes. For some couples, the retirement reveals a marriage that is empty. The marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours, is hollow, in the form the marriage now takes.

The retirement is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The retirement is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 3. The Infidelity That Was Discovered, or That Happened, Later in Life.**

The infidelity is the third most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The infidelity is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage was, is broken, in the form the breaking now takes.

The infidelity at 55+ is different from the infidelity at 30. The infidelity at 30 is the infidelity of the early marriage, in the form the early marriage now takes. The infidelity at 55+ is the infidelity of the long marriage, in the form the long marriage now takes. The infidelity at 55+ comes after 25 or 30 or 35 years of marriage, in the form the long marriage now takes.

For some couples, the infidelity is discovered. The spouse has been unfaithful, and the discovery comes, in the form the discovery now takes, in the form of a phone, a credit card statement, a conversation, a confession. The discovery is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the infidelity is acknowledged. The spouse has been unfaithful, and the spouse confesses, in the form the confession now takes. The confession is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the infidelity is mutual. Both spouses have been unfaithful, in the form the unfaithful now takes. The mutual unfaithfulness is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The infidelity is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The infidelity is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 4. The Substance Abuse That Was Tolerated, or That Became Unbearable.**

The substance abuse is the fourth most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The substance abuse is the moment when the drinking, or the drug use, or the gambling, or the prescription medication, becomes the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the substance abuse has been there, in the form the substance abuse now takes, for the whole marriage. The substance abuse has been the undercurrent, in the form the undercurrent now takes. The substance abuse has been the thing that was not talked about, in the form the not talking now takes.

For some couples, the substance abuse is new. The retirement, or the empty nest, or the loss of a parent, or the diagnosis of a disease, has triggered the substance abuse, in the form the triggering now takes. The new substance abuse is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the substance abuse has become unbearable. The spouse can no longer tolerate the substance abuse, in the form the tolerating now takes. The unbearability is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The substance abuse is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The substance abuse is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 5. The Financial Conflict That Became the Breaking.**

The financial conflict is the fifth most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The financial conflict is the moment when the money, in the form the money now takes, becomes the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the spending. One spouse spends. The other spouse saves. The spending is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the debt. One spouse has hidden debt. The hidden debt is discovered, in the form the discovery now takes. The hidden debt is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the retirement. The retirement accounts are not enough. The retirement is in danger. The danger is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the inheritance. The inheritance is contested. The contesting is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The financial conflict is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The financial conflict is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 6. The Caregiving That Became the Marriage.**

The caregiving is the sixth most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The caregiving is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage was, becomes the marriage of the caregiver and the cared-for, in the form the caregiver and the cared-for now takes.

For some couples, the caregiving is for an aging parent. One spouse is the caregiver for an aging parent, in the form the caregiving now takes. The caregiving is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The spouse who is not the caregiver feels left out, in the form the left out now takes. The left-out feeling is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the caregiving is for the spouse. One spouse has a chronic illness, and the other spouse is the caregiver, in the form the caregiving now takes. The caregiving is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The caregiver spouse is exhausted, in the form the exhausting now takes. The exhausted feeling is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The caregiving is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The caregiving is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 7. The "I Never Loved You" That Was Finally Said.**

The "I never loved you" is the seventh most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The "I never loved you" is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage was, is unmasked, in the form the unmasking now takes.

The "I never loved you" comes, in the form the coming now takes, after 25 or 30 or 35 years of marriage. The "I never loved you" comes when the empty nest, or the retirement, or the illness, or the loss, removes the reasons for staying in the marriage, in the form the reasons now take.

The "I never loved you" is the moment when the spouse, who has been hiding the truth, in the form the hiding now takes, finally says the truth, in the form the saying now takes. The saying is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The "I never loved you" is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for some gray divorces. The "I never loved you" is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

- The 7 things, in summary.**

The 7 things that drive gray divorce are:

1. The empty nest that reveals the void
2. The retirement that reveals the distance
3. The infidelity that was discovered or that happened later in life
4. The substance abuse that was tolerated or that became unbearable
5. The financial conflict that became the breaking
6. The caregiving that became the marriage
7. The "I never loved you" that was finally said

The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are the most common reasons. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

- The work of the chapter.**

The work of this chapter is to name the 7 things. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, which of the 7 things is in your marriage, in the form the marriage now takes.

The work of this chapter is also to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, that the 7 things are not the only things. The 7 things are the most common. The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the second phase of the gray divorce decision. The work of this chapter is the work of the reckoning. The reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR & THE CARE MISSION

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Sanjay Shharma is an Author, Corporate Executive Mentor, and Businessman holding an M.Sc., MBA, and APSCM from the prestigious **Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta**, with thirty years in corporate executive management.

Having lost his wife of many years to chronic cancer, he served as her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He sat on cold hospital stairs, held her hand through 3 a.m. alarms, learned the silence of marriage when words no longer suffice, and walked the slow journey of grief and rebuilding.

He created **The Care Collection** because conventional relationship advice is too often written for newlyweds or clinical theorists. Mature couples facing empty nests, long silences, aging parents, memory loss, and life disruptions need practical, honest frameworks written by someone who has lived every side of marriage — the ambitious partner, the exhausted caregiver, and the one left behind.

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